Democrats win Congress

The Democrats won the House and the Senate. Many people say the result is a message for the president.

Level 1 · A2 · 160 words · 10.7 words per sentence · 5 glossed

On Tuesday, November 3, Americans voted in the midterms. These elections happen in the middle of a president's four years. The president is Donald Trump, and he was not on the ballot.

The result is clear: the Democrats won the House of Representatives, and they won the Senate too. Before the vote, the Republicans had both.

In the Senate, the Republicans had 53 seats and the Democrats had 47. Now the Democrats have 54. Some races are too close to call, so the final numbers can change.

Why did people want a change? AP, a news group, says three things were important: high prices, the war in Iran, and corruption in the government.

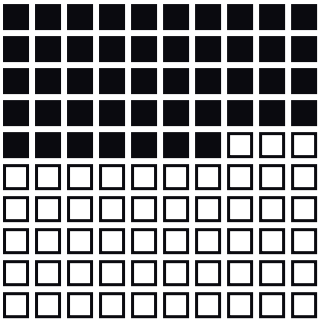
President Trump said he will accept the results. He said this is not a loss for him, and that people did not like some Republican candidates. He also said he will veto laws from the Democrats.

The new Congress starts on January 3. Until then, the Republicans still control the Senate.

GLOSSARY

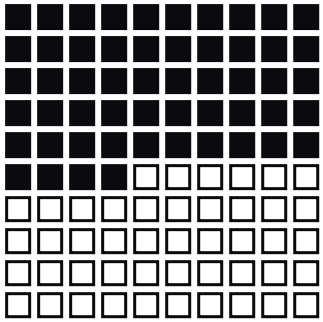
midterms	eleições de meio de mandato
on the ballot	na cédula
seats	cadeiras
too close to call	apertadas demais para dar o resultado
accept	aceitar

THE SENATE, 100 SEATS



47

Before the vote



54

Nov 4, 2026

■ Democrats (and 2 independents)

□ Republicans

In 2026, the empty squares are Republican seats or seats not yet called.

Source: AP and news reports, Nov 4, 2026. Some races were still being counted.

Two systems, side by side

In the text: the House = *a Câmara dos Deputados*, the Senate = o *Senado Federal*. Both countries have two chambers, but they work in different ways.

	UNITED STATES	BRASIL
TWO CHAMBERS	House of Representatives and Senate	*Câmara dos Deputados* and *Senado Federal*
SEATS	435 in the House, 100 in the Senate	513 *deputados*, 81 *senadores*
SENATORS	2 for each state	3 for each state and for the Federal District (*Distrito Federal*)
TERMS	House: 2 years. Senate: 6 years.	*Câmara*: 4 years. *Senado*: 8 years.
ELECTIONS	Every 2 years: the whole House and one third of the Senate. The president is chosen in a different year, so these elections fall in the middle of the president's term. That is why they are called midterms.	Every 4 years, all together: president, governors, *Câmara* and part of the Senate (one third, then two thirds). There is no midterm for Congress. The elections 2 years later are for mayors (*prefeitos*).
WHO GETS A SEAT	House: each district elects one member. The candidate with the most votes wins.	*Câmara*: parties win seats in proportion to their votes. Each state has from 8 to 70 deputies, depending on its population.
VETO	To override a veto, two thirds of each chamber must vote against it.	To override a veto (*derrubar o veto*), an absolute majority of each chamber is enough: 257 deputies and 41 senators, in a joint session.
THE PRESIDENT'S PICKS	The Senate approves cabinet members, judges and ambassadors.	The *Senado* approves ambassadors and Supreme Court (STF) judges. Ministers do not need approval.
IMPEACHMENT	The House accuses, by a simple majority. The Senate judges: two thirds must vote to remove.	The *Câmara* must authorize it: 342 of 513 votes. The *Senado* judges: 54 of 81 votes remove the president.

Sources: Senado Federal, Câmara dos Deputados, Constituição Federal (arts. 45, 46, 52, 66), U.S. Constitution.

AFTER READING

1. Who was on the ballot on November 3, and who was not?
2. According to the AP, what did voters care about?
3. Do you think the results of midterm elections change how much power a president has? Why?

SOURCES

PBS NewsHour (AP), Democrats win control of U.S. House, in major rebuke to Trump

Al Jazeera, Democrats win Congress: How they did it, and what it means

Time, Democrats Win Control of Both House and Senate in Huge Blow to Trump

CBS News, 2026 midterm election updates as fallout begins over sweeping Democratic victories

CNBC, Midterm Election Day recap: Democrats flip Senate and House

Senado Federal, Perguntas frequentes

Câmara dos Deputados, The Federal Senate

U.S. News, 2026 Midterm Election Results: Maps Show How Democrats Took Congress